28

The Crisis of the Imperial Order, 1900–1929

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On June 28, 1914, Archduke Franz Ferdinand, heir to the throne of Austria-Hungary, passed beside the river in an open carriage in Sarajevo, a city Austria had annexed six years earlier. When the carriage stopped momentarily, Gavrilo Princip, member of a pro-Serbian conspiracy, fired his pistol twice, killing the archduke and his wife.

Those shots ignited a global conflict. All previous wars had caused death and destruction, but they had also been marked by heroism and glory. In this new war, four years of bitter fighting produced no true victories, few gains, and no glory; only death for millions of soldiers and dismemberment for three empires. The war became global as the Ottoman empire fought against Britain and Japan attacked German positions in China. France and Britain involved their empires in the war and brought Africans, Indians, Australians, and Canadians to Europe to fight and labor on the front lines. Finally, in 1917, the United States entered the fray.

In this chapter, we look at the causes, conduct, and consequences of the war in Europe, the Middle East, and Russia. We also discuss the end of the Austro-Hungarian, Tsarist, and Ottoman empires, and postwar upheavals in China and Japan. ■



▲ **Image 28.1 Trench Warfare in World War I** No one anticipated the horrors of trench warfare in which tens of thousands of men excavated positions below ground level while their enemies did the same on the other side of a no-man's-land pockmarked by shell craters, bordered by barbed wire, and swept by machine gun fire. Among innumerable depictions by writers and artists, this one focuses on mud up to the soldiers' knees. Godong/Alamy Stock Photo

28-1 Origins of the Crisis in Europe and the Middle East

Focus Question What led to the outbreak of the First World War?

When the twentieth century opened, the world seemed firmly under the control of the Great Powers (see Chapter 27). The first decade of the twentieth century saw a period of relative peace and economic growth in most of the world. Several new technologies—airplanes, automobiles, radio, and cinema—aroused much excitement (see Chapter 30). The Great Powers consolidated their colonial conquests of the previous decades, and their alliances had roughly equal capacity. The primary international war of the period, the Russo–Japanese War (1904–1905), ended quickly with a decisive Japanese victory.

However, two major changes undermined the apparent stability. In Europe, tensions mounted as Germany, with its growing industrial and military might, challenged Britain at sea and France in Morocco. And the Ottoman Empire lost territory to nationalistic movements in the Balkans. The resulting power vacuum gradually drew the European powers into a web of hostilities.

28-1a The Ottoman Empire and the Balkans

From the fifteenth to the nineteenth centuries, the Ottoman Empire constituted an undeniably powerful state, albeit suffering from internal disarray as time went on (see Chapter 24). By the late nineteenth century, however, it had fallen behind Europe's most prosperous states economically, technologically, and militarily. European statesmen referred to it as the "sick man of Europe."

As the Ottoman Empire weakened, it began losing European provinces: Macedonia in 1902–1903, Bosnia in 1908, Crete in 1909, Albania in 1910. In 1912, Italy conquered Libya, the Ottomans' last foothold in Africa. In the two Balkan Wars of 1912 and 1913, Serbia, Bulgaria, Romania, and Greece chased the Ottomans out of Europe, except for a small enclave around Constantinople.

In reaction, the Turks began to assert themselves against rebellious minorities and meddling foreigners. Many officers in the army, the most Europeanized segment of Turkish society, blamed Sultan Abdul Hamid II (r. 1876–1909) for the decline of the empire. A group known as "Young Turks" plotted to force the sultan to reinstate a stillborn constitution that he had suspended in 1876 before it could have an impact. They alienated other anti-Ottoman groups by advocating centralized rule and the Turkification of ethnic minorities.

In 1909, the parliament, dominated by Young Turks, overthrew Abdul Hamid. The new regime reinvigorated the Tanzimat reform movement that had begun in the early nineteenth century. At the same time, it looked with suspicion on Greek and Armenian minorities. Galvanized by their defeat in the Balkan Wars, the Turks hired a German general to modernize their armed forces. The dangerous mixture of modern armies and nationalism went beyond the Ottoman Empire, however.

28-1b Nationalism, Alliances, and Military Strategy

The assassination of Franz Ferdinand triggered a chain of events over which military and political leaders lost control. The escalation from royal assassination to global war had causes that went back many years. One, nationalism, identified citizens with their ethnic group and urged them, when called upon, to kill others they viewed as enemies. The system of alliances and military planning that the Great Powers had devised to protect themselves from their rivals formed another. And third came Germany's yearning to dominate Europe.

Nationalism united the citizens of France, Britain, Italy, and Germany behind their respective governments and gave them tremendous cohesion and strength of purpose. Only the most powerful feelings could inspire millions of men to march into battle and sustain civilian populations through years of hardship.

Nationalism could also be a dividing force. The Russian, Austro–Hungarian, and Ottoman Empires, large but fragile, contained numerous ethnic and religious minorities. Having repressed some minorities for centuries, the governments could never count on their full support. The very existence of an independent Serbia threatened Austria–Hungary by stirring up the hopes and resentments of its Slavic populations.

Imbued with nationalism, most people viewed war as a crusade for liberty or as long-overdue revenge for past injustices. As memories of the misery and carnage caused by the Napoleonic Wars slowly faded after 1815, revulsion against war gradually weakened. The Crimean War of 1853–1856 and the Franco-Prussian War of 1871 had generated few casualties or long-term consequences. And in the imperialist wars in Africa and Asia (see Chapter 26), Europeans almost always won out over local forces at a small cost in money and manpower.

The system of alliances turned an incident in the Balkans into a great power conflict. At the center of Europe stood Germany, the continent's most heavily industrialized country. Its army the best trained and equipped, its navy challenged Great Britain's supremacy at sea by building "dreadnoughts"—heavily armed battleships. In 1882, it joined Austria–Hungary and Italy in the Triple Alliance, while France allied itself with Russia. In 1904, Britain and France reached an *entente* **(on-TONT)** ("understanding"), joined by Russia in 1907. Europe thus divided into two blocs of roughly equal power (see Map 28.1).

Unfortunately, the alliance system depended on inflexible military planning. In 1914, western and central Europe had highly developed railroad networks but very few motor vehicles, and European armies had grown to include millions of soldiers and reservists. To mobilize these forces and transport them to battle would require thousands of trains running on precise schedules. Once under way, a country's mobilization could not be canceled or postponed without causing chaos.

Military planners in France and Germany worked out elaborate railroad timetables to mobilize their respective armies in a few days. Russia, a vast country with a limited rail system, needed several weeks to mobilize its forces. Britain, with a tiny volunteer army, had no mobilization plans, and German planners believed that the British would stay out of a war on the European continent. To avoid having to fight France and Russia at the same time, German war planners

and North America	Middle East	
French entente Russian entente	**1909** Young Turks overthrow Sultan Abdul Hamid	**1900** Boxer uprising in China **1904–1905** Russo–Japanese War
alkan Wars nation of Archduke Franz parks World War I of Verdun and the Somme Revolutions; United States war ce ends World War I Civil war in Russia of Versailles	**1912** Italy conquers Libya, last Ottoman territory in Africa **1915** British defeat at Gallipoli **1916** Arab Revolt in Arabia **1917** Balfour Declaration **1919–1922** War between Turkey and Greece	**1911** Chinese revolutionaries led by Sun Yat-sen overthrow Qing dynasty **1915** Japan presents Twenty-One Demands to China **1919** May Fourth Movement in China
New Economic Policy in	**1922** Egypt nominally independent **1923** Mustafa Kemal proclaims Turkey a republic	**1927** Guomindang forces occupy Shanghai and expel Communists

counted on defeating France in a matter of days, then transporting their entire army across Germany to the Russian border by train before Russia could fully mobilize.

On July 28, 1914, Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia. The declaration of war triggered the mobilization plans of Russia, France, and Germany. On July 29, the Russian government ordered general mobilization to force Austria to back down. On August 1, France ordered general mobilization; minutes later, Germany did likewise. Because of the rigid railroad timetables, war now became inevitable.

The Germans planned to wheel through neutral Belgium and invade France from the north. The German General Staff expected France to capitulate before the British could get involved. But on August 3, when German troops entered Belgium, Britain demanded their withdrawal. When Germany refused, Britain declared war on Germany.

Section Review

Empire declined, nationalists calling
g Turks tried to create a new Turkish

- Nationalism, competing alliances, and inflexible military plans based on railroads turned an assassination into a cause for war.

28-2 The "Great War" and the Russian Revolutions, 1914–1918

Focus Question How did the war lead to revolution in Russia?

Throughout Europe, people greeted the outbreak
expecting a quick victory. German troops
encouraged their troops with